

Pledge to Win This War

I am angry. India is angry. Very angry. And rightly so. All of us feel violated, helpless and frustrated. The Mumbai tragedy seems to be the last straw which has broken the camel's back. Since 1998 India has had over 2,000 die in terrorist violence. We are only second to Iraq in this grim statistic and they are in a civil war. It is not only the audacity and the ruthlessness of the attack on India's financial capital but that it has been preceded by 11 terrorist attacks in all our major cities (Ahmedabad, Jaipur, Hyderabad, Guwahati, Delhi, Mumbai, Bangalore, Gandhinagar, Varanasi and Malegaon) over the last seven years. Not to forget the outrageous attack in 2001 on the heart of our democracy—our Parliament. Our anger comes from the fact that despite all these attacks the Indian state has learnt nothing and we remain vulnerable as ever. It's a complete failure of our political and bureaucratic classes.

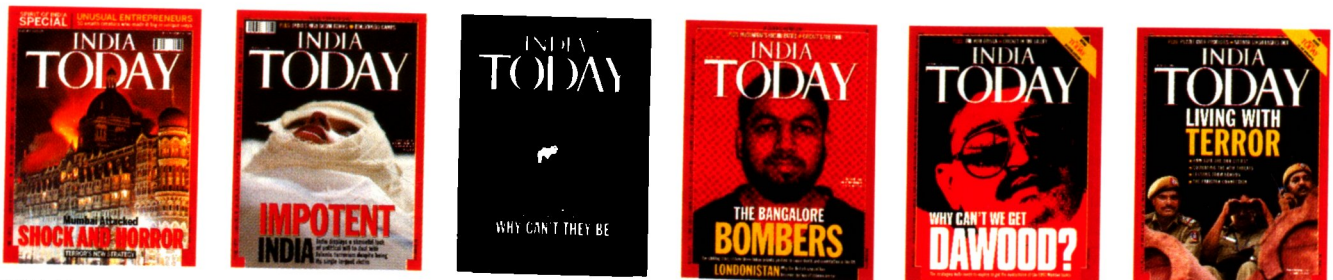
We have long been known as a soft state. We are not that alone. We are a rotten state whose insides have been pillaged by politicians and bureaucrats who masquerade as public servants. This country is still mired in poverty (according to the Government's own report, 77 per cent live on less than Rs 20 per day), illiteracy and disease abound after 61 years of Independence. Now after six decades, the state cannot even perform its basic function of protecting its citizens, never mind giving them a better life. The so-called liberalisation which we have lauded so much since 1991 is nothing but the government loosening its stranglehold on us and letting our productive and creative energies flourish. No wonder the private sector in India is so dynamic but everything to do with the government turns into a kiss of death. It makes for unresponsive, lethargic and unreliable governance.

We are a rotten state because corruption runs through the whole system. Politicians appoint bureaucrats and policemen who will curry favour with them and do their bidding. Merit is the last consideration. Critical equipment like Coast Guard ships, flak jackets, guns, ammunition are not purchased because someone's palm is not greased or substandard equipment is

bought because palms are greased. So when a constable's antiquated gun jams when confronted with terrorists, no one is held accountable. Nobody of any seniority really gets punished. At worse, they could be transferred to await the return of a favourable political master to give them a plum posting. Members of Parliament get caught taking bribes and nothing happens. So, if this is the state of our higher echelons, we should be angry but we shouldn't be surprised.

Also, we shouldn't be surprised by the brazenness of the terrorist attacks as terrorists see India as an impotent state. And they have reason to. Look at the milestones of our mentality towards terror. In November 1989, when Rubaiya Sayeed, daughter of Union home minister Mufti Mohammed Sayeed (during V.P. Singh's premiership) was kidnapped in Srinagar, the terrorists asked for the release of five JKLF militants. The government of India succumbed and these militants were released. The other was, of course, the infamous IC-814 hijack in 1999 where external affairs minister Jaswant Singh personally delivered three terrorists in Afghanistan, including Maulana Masood Azhar who went back and set up Jaish-e-Mohammed, a terror organisation targeting India. Ironically, we are asking now for his return after the Mumbai attack. Two years later there was the shocking attack on Parliament where five terrorists almost entered the Parliament building. Fortunately, they were all gunned down; one surviving co-conspirator Afzal Guru who was convicted after three years and sentenced to death has now become a football for our votebank politics. His mercy petition remains in suspended animation.

If you were a Pakistan general who wanted to destabilise India for strategic reasons and had plenty of jihadi cannon fodder amongst the multitude of terrorists outfits nurtured by the army, what would you do? You would keep coming up with one devious plan after another to upset your big neighbour whose economic



OUR LAST SIX COVERS ON TERROR BETWEEN DECEMBER 2008 AND AUGUST 2006